The messianic settler movement, Gush Emunim (“the bloc of the faithful”), was founded after the Yom Kippur War of October 1973, in a meeting at Rabbi Zvi Yehuda Kook’s Yeshivat Harav (“the rabbi’s yeshiva”). The meeting brought together extreme right-wing and extreme Orthodox figures, all of them believing that messianic redemption had started with the conquest of the whole land of Israel in June 1967.

My friend Uriel Tal, whom I already mentioned, a prominent scholar of Jewish Studies at Tel Aviv University, presented a close analysis of Gush Emunim’s publications, particularly of their magazine *Nekuda* (Point), and concluded that they were an Israeli version of fascism. They were. Uri did not hesitate, moreover, to compare the policy of settlements in the Occupied Territories to the Nazi colonization policy in the conquered East. Another late friend and colleague of mine, Amos Funkenstein, a polymath if there ever was one, compared Israeli policies toward the Palestinians to Nazi policies in the first years of the regime. I admit to not following Uri and Amos in these comparisons, because I feared that readers, when they read “Nazi,” read “extermination,” and that certainly was not what my friends meant.

Friday, January 27

Yesterday, a major operation in the Jenin refugee camp: ten Palestinians killed (including an elderly woman). Exchange of fire with the Gaza Strip. In the evening, a Palestinian from East Jerusalem ambushes people at the Neve Yaakov synagogue, north of Jerusalem: seven dead. Later, a thirteen-year-old Palestinian kid shoots and wounds two people. This is a terrible phase in an endless vicious circle. The ultras urge a fiercer clampdown; in my opinion, popular anti-Israeli violence can only be kept at a low level by the easing of restrictions on the Palestinian population and negotiations for a two-state solution.